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THE NOVELTY OF TOTALITARIANISM IN THE HISTORY OF WESTERN CIVILIZATION

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(Evening Lecture, November 17, 1939, in Symposium on The Totalitarian State)

If totalitarianism were synonymous with dictatorship, the subject of the following remarks would be pointless. For dictatorship is no novelty of the present age. Twenty-five centuries ago it was exemplified in the Greek matrix of our distinctively Western civilization by tyrants like Periander of Corinth and Peisistratus of Athens. Two thousand years ago, when the seat of that civilization had moved from Greece to Rome, dictatorship in the tradition of Alexander the Great was revitalized by Julius Caesar; and thenceforth it was the ideal and usually the practice of long lines of Caesars—Constantine, Justinian, and all the emperors of Byzantium down to 1453; Charlemagne, Otto, and all the Holy Roman Emperors down to 1806; Ivan, Peter, and all the autocratic Russian Tsars down to 1917. The brilliant age of Humanism, five hundred years ago, was an age of Italian despots. The pregnant age of the Enlightenment, two hundred years ago, was an age of enlightened despots—Frederick of Prussia, Charles of Spain, Joseph of Austria. Only one hundred and twenty-five years separate us from the great dictator Napoleon Bonaparte; only seventy, from the little dictator Louis Napoleon. While on the frontiers of Western civilization —in Latin America and the Balkans—the common garden variety of dictator has continued to flourish like any hardy perennial.

Dictatorship or despotism or tyranny, call it as one may, is, then, a constant, or at least a recurrent, *motif* in the whole history of Western civilization. It is as much a characteristic of bright as of dark ages. It is equally apparent in formative Greek times, in fully developed Christian eras, in epochs of rationalism or reaction. In fact, it is as constant or recurrent as that other and contradictory *motif* in the history of our civilization, the *motif* of individual liberty and representative

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government. For this, too, let me remind you, is no novelty. It has had repeated and manifold expression in Athenian democracy and Roman republic, in feudal contracts, in medieval communes, guilds, and estates, in Italian and German city republics, in Swiss cantons, in English and American and French revolutions, in the numberless written constitutions and elected parliaments of the last two hundred years. Liberty and tyranny, democracy and dictatorship, such contradictions and antitheses occur and recur throughout the whole history of the Occident as if to prove to every generation the truth of Aristotle's ancient dictum that an excess of the one automatically produces the other.

But though dictatorship of itself is no novelty, a new genus of dictator has arisen in our generation. Previously the successful despot came of good family and usually possessed excellent education and military fame. Such was the case alike with the Greek tyrants of antiquity and with the Spanish-American dictators of the last century. Alexander the Great had been tutored by no less a scholar and scientist than Aristotle, and it would be hard to find any petty Latin-American dictator who had not commanded at least a regiment and fortified himself with the positivist philosophy of Auguste Comte. Certainly the Italian despots of early modern times were men of culture as well as prowess, and the royal despots of the eighteenth century were products of the most selective eugenics and the most meticulous education. Even Napoleon Bonaparte was a scion of the Corsican aristocracy and a graduate of the aristocratic French military school of Brienne; he was the leading general before becoming the outstanding dictator of his age.

In contrast with the quality and training of earlier dictators, note who and what the present ones are. There is Benito Mussolini, whose father was a blacksmith, whose education was obtained in a minor normal school, whose career was that of an unsuccessful elementary-school teacher and a second- or third-rate journalist, and whose military service was brief and inconspicuous. There is Joseph Stalin, generated by a peasant shoemaker, dismissed from a seminary and further schooling at the age of seventeen for irregularity in conduct and discipline, self-trained in the strong-arm arts of highway robbery and factory disorder, and as a convicted criminal relieved of any military

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service in the World War. There is Adolf Hitler, son of a minor Austrian customs-official, with a minimum of formal schooling and a maximum of frustrated efforts at hack work in painting and drawing, and with a curious record of having fought for four years in the German army without rising above the rank of corporal. In fine, not one of these world-shaking despots of our day comes of what we would deem distinguished antecedents; not one of them has been well educated or gained military repute.

How has it happened that such persons could become dictators? It is, I submit, precisely because they have come from the masses rather than from the classes and could therefore more readily get the ear of the masses. For the masses count nowadays as never before, and this is the first and most fundamental of the novelties which distinguish contemporary dictatorship and the totalitarianism accompanying it.

Though European civilization has been inhospitable to any rigid caste system, such as that in India, it has traditionally harbored classes and class distinctions and been respectful of them. Even Christianity, which so long and so effectively molded our civilization, was not conducive to the wiping out of classes or to the abating of honors paid them. The equality which it preached was an equality of souls before God, an equality in dignity of human personality. It was not an equality of minds or of purses, of talents or of occupations. And the precept of *noblesse oblige* was an essentially Christian consecration of the classes to service of the masses, with implicit reminder to the masses that they in turn should respect the classes. How universal and persistent has been such a conception of the relationship between classes and masses is evidenced by the fact that in every European parliament which functioned at any time between the Middle Ages and the middle of the last century persons who could vote belonged to special classes and were presumed to represent the inarticulate and non-voting masses. Right up to the present day, moreover, the surviving congresses and parliaments, chosen though they are by universal suffrage, are replete not with peasants, mechanics, stevedores, and other members of the ordinary populace but rather with landlords, bankers, lawyers, and similar persons of substance and education from among the restricted upper and middle classes. Until

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recently, at any rate, cats could look at kings but they did not aspire to be kings.

Now a radical change is occurring. Cats want to be kings and, through sheer press of numbers, some of them actually become kings. It is an aspect of the new and widespread "revolt of the masses," which the Spanish philosopher, Ortega y Gasset, described a few years ago with prophetic insight. Perhaps "revolt of the masses" is too journalistic and strong a term. "Self-conscious emergence of the masses" would probably be more accurate. At any rate, a significant transformation has come over the masses in recent times. It represents a response in part to such external stimuli as popular compulsory schooling and popular "yellow" journalism, and in part to such stimuli within the masses as trade-unionism, the coöperative movement, and the propaganda of Marxian socialism. But underlying all these stimuli and providing a favorable field for them is the intensive industrialization of our day, with its attendant dislocation of the masses. Always before, the masses have been relatively settled in body and mind. Now they are migratory, nomadic, almost Gypsy-like. They move from country to country, from country to city, from city to city, from one tenement to another. This means that a vast and growing number of them are what the French call *déraçinés,* uprooted from ancestral soil, from established habit and tradition, from personal responsibility. They experience, furthermore, an extraordinary economic insecurity, which is apt to produce an extraordinary psychological maladjustment. And huddled and agglomerated as they are in overgrown cities, they are peculiarly susceptible to demagogic purveying of easy panaceas, especially by those who assure them that they shall no longer be mere minor cogs in machine-industry but major wheels in affairs of state, full-fledged comrades suitably shirted.

All this appeals with full force to the youth among the masses. Youth is notoriously more adventurous than age, more idealistic and less stable, more open to suggestion and less hesitant about acting upon it; and the present generation of youth, while provided with unusual opportunities for schooling and recreation, for sport and physical development, finds its opportunities for remunerative employment sharply curtailed or indefinitely postponed. No wonder that contemporary dictator-

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ship is a mass-movement, and especially a youth-movement. Hitler, Stalin, and Mussolini were all under forty-five years of age when they became dictators, and of their several movements, youth has been the vanguard and spearhead.

There is another novel trend of our age which affects the masses and forwards dictatorship—and totalitarianism. It is a decline of traditional religion and an obscuring of religious values. In the past every civilization has been builded upon a particular religious profession and upon the popular *mores* emanating from it; and to this generalization our occidental civilization is no exception. The background of all that is distinctively Western is Graeco-Roman paganism, and central to the spacious foreground is Judaeo-Roman Christianity. To countless generations of our ancestors, regardless of nationality or class, the Christian faith was the impelling ideology and the Christian ethic the standard of conduct. We must admit that this holds true no longer, though I wonder if we fully appreciate how very recently the change has occurred. For two centuries some of the classes, especially intellectuals, have been repudiating our common religious heritage, but indifference or hostility of the masses towards it, of the rural as well as the urban masses, is a strictly contemporary phenomenon. How this has come about, I shall not here attempt to suggest. I merely remark the fact, which seems to me self-evident, and pass on to an important consequence. No man, whether he be Western or Eastern, lives by bread alone. Everybody must have faith, a faith in some mysterious power outside of one's self, a faith attested by feelings of reverence and expressed in external acts and ceremonials. When a man loses faith in one religion, he naturally attaches himself consciously or unconsciously to another object of worship. It may be worship of Christ; it may be worship of totem or fetish; it may likewise be worship of science or humanity—provided these concepts are written in his mind with capital letters.

In the present crisis, when the historic Christian faith of the Western masses grows cold, a kind of religious void is created for them. But inasmuch as any such void is unnatural and eventually unendurable, the masses promptly seek to fill it with some new faith. This they hardly find in "humanity" or "science," which are too abstract and intellectual and nowadays

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a bit stale. They find it rather in materialistic communism or in nationalistic deification of blood and soil. Indeed, we miss a main point about the nature of contemporary communism and nationalism and their relationship to contemporary dictatorship if we overlook the essentially religious element in them and the essentially religious appeal they make. It is as high priests of novel and fervent religions that the dictators of today appeal to the masses. It is as recent converts that the masses respond enthusiastically and fanatically to the appeals of dictators.

So far I have dwelt upon certain features of dictatorship which are peculiar to our age—its origin in the masses rather than the classes, its close association with youth, and its personification of popular religious change. Let me now speak of totalitarianism, which is something more than dictatorship and which, unlike dictatorship, is a brand-new event in the history of Western civilization.

From time immemorial Western civilization has developed under what may be termed a pluralism of sovereignties. Whatever might be the theory at any given time, the practice for centuries has been to distribute state-powers between a central government and a congeries of local governments. To the latter usually belonged the care of roads, the administration of common justice, the raising and support of militia, the dispensing of poor relief. The central government had enough to do to maintain a court and an army. For centuries, moreover, state-powers, whether exercised locally or centrally, were limited by the powers accorded by custom or charter to semi-public, semi-independent corporations like church, nobility, guild, or university. Most educational and charitable work was the concern of church, not of state. Industry and commerce were long regulated less by state than by craft- or merchant-guild. Even so-called absolutist states respected privileges of nobility and of universities and recognized the rights of parents and a large degree of family autonomy.

Several developments in modern times have contributed to the breakdown of that pluralism: the gradual secularizing of religion and the universities; the rise of liberalism with its atomizing of society and its warfare on privileged corporations; the French Revolution; and, most recent and fateful of all, the Industrial Revolution, which has created unprecedented eco-

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nomic and social problems and at the same time furnished the state with unprecedented opportunities and incentives for expanding its activities. The outcome is today manifest: a centralizing in the state of all sorts of functions—military, judicial, administrative—commercial, industrial, agricultural, labor—educational, charitable, health, even family; and an exercising of this totality of functions less and less locally and more and more by the central national government. It is what the French call *étatisme,* and some measure of it is evident today in all industrialized countries, whether republican or monarchical, democratic or dictatorial.

It is conceivable that a democracy, already far advanced in *étatisme,* might become outright totalitarian; it would merely utilize an elected majority instead of a dictator to gather all power in its hands and crush minority dissent. Actually, however, this has not yet happened, nor is it likely to happen. Democracy may break down, as it did in Italy and Germany, but it is an ensuing dictatorship which completes the transition to totalitarianism. Naturally so, because democratic government is apt to be cumbersome and sluggish; and the greater and more numerous are the functions which it is called upon to perform, the more cumbersome and sluggish it becomes; with the result that persons who are eager for quick, drastic action and who demand efficiency at any cost lose patience with democracy and yearn for a strong man—a dictator. Responsibility which should be theirs close at hand they nonchalantly shove off on a fabulous figure afar. With rapture they listen to the ambitious demagogue and welcome the advent of dictatorship, and it is their expectation of prompt and manifold miracles to be wrought by it which renders dictatorship the natural vehicle for totalitarianism.

I am not contending that the recent trends which I have mentioned—the increase of *étatisme,* the loosening hold of traditional religion, the self-conscious emergence of the masses—render totalitarianism inevitable. I am neither of Calvinist nor of Marxian proclivities, and I am sceptical of any historic determinism. Totalitarianism is not universal, and I doubt if it ever will be. Not all the emerging masses in every country are in revolt. Traditional religion may be in decline, but surely it has not lost all influence everywhere. In many countries, too,

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there are still enough limitations and divisions of the functions and powers of government—enough pluralism—to check indefinitely the drift toward totalitarian dictatorship. Besides, wherever this kind of dictatorship has triumphed, it has been the achievement not of a deliberative majority but of an active minority, a result of pressure politics; and in each instance it has followed something like a national cataclysm: war and despair in Russia, defeat and humiliation in Germany, disorder and disillusionment in Italy. However, a believer in democracy should not be unduly optimistic. The new sort of totalitarian dictatorship is an extraordinarily substantial affair, and, once it is established, it is not likely to be ended except through another and very terrible cataclysm. On the other hand, a democracy may presumably be carried into totalitarian dictatorship through cataclysmic misfortune exploited by a demagogue, a militant minority, and pressure politics. Which only heightens the danger of a great international war as the biggest possible gamble on cataclysms.

I have now reached the point where, with your continuing indulgence, I may summarize what I believe to be the specific novelties of dictatorial totalitarianism.

First, it is really totalitarian. It monopolizes all powers and directs all activities of individuals and groups. It subordinates to itself all economic, religious, and educational institutions and policies. It levels classes and restricts or suppresses the liberty of family and person. It leaves no room for the free play of individual wills and recognizes no utility in free inquiry. On the contrary, it has a passion for making everyone conform to the will and thought of the governing party and dictator. Alike to Communists and to Fascists, the state is omniscient and infallible as well as omnipotent. In all these respects the Russia of Stalin is totalitarian as the Russia of the Tsars never was, the Germany of Hitler as no divine-right monarchy of Hohenzollerns or Habsburgs ever was.

Second, it commands and rests upon mass-support. It is no affair of an aristocratic class or a military caste. It is frankly for and by the half-educated and half-propertied lower middle class and upper proletariat. It springs from and returns to the great median of what are truly the masses, and everyone above or below who is not sycophantic is suspect and liable to liquida-

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tion. Previous régimes may have been aristocratic or plutocratic, but at least they had a tolerance for the masses which these, under the new dictatorship, seldom evince for the classes. And despite past apologies for Fascism in Italy and National Socialism in Germany on the ground that they were last-ditch defenses against the anti-capitalist Communism of Russia, time has already shown that their real defense has been piece-meal capitulation to the same socializing of goods and the same levelling of persons, which latter is a levelling down and not a levelling up.

Third, totalitarian dictatorship is maintained, and its overthrow rendered unusually difficult, by novel and marvellously effective agencies of popular education and propaganda. The radio and amplifier only date from after the World War; the cinema, from just before that war. The production of wood-pulp paper and large-scale cheap journalism arose in the 1890's, and compulsory school attendance began only in the 1880's and then only in a very few countries. Now all these agencies are perfected, and ready to be seized and used by a dictator. Once in power, the dictator immediately decrees a monopoly and extension of state schools. Private and religious schools are suppressed, and in the public schools, which have been greatly extended not only in Hitlerian Germany but more sensationally in Russia under Stalin and in Italy under Mussolini, every child is forcibly fed with mental pabulum nicely calculated to make him an unquestioning devotee of a given brand of totalitarian despotism. Everyone learns to read, of course; that is a favorite boast of contemporary dictators. It does flatter the masses, and it probably renders them more gullible than they would be if they could not read. For what they later read—and hear—is as closely prescribed or censored as the content of their elementary schooling. The whole publishing business is "coördinated"—this is the technical term—with the state, and there is nothing to read of which the state disapproves. Cinema and radio are outright state monopolies; the one flicks at the popular eye, the other dins into the popular ear, only what the régime adjudges advantageous to itself; and Hitler with an amplifier is more frightful—and far more effective—than was Napoleon without one.

Again, totalitarianism has an almost irresistible allure—it

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moves people—by reason of the emotional and essentially religious spirit which its leading apostles have infused into it. Communist Russia and Nazi Germany are churches as well as states, and they are churches not old and conventional but pristine and full of missionary zeal. Their mythologies (that is, their ideologies) are new; their banners and rituals and slogans are new. No wonder that the number of their first-generation converts is incomparable. Masses of people who have lost contact with old gods want new, and now they get them—a Dionysus-like tribal god of blood and soil, a Lucretian god of fatalism and materialism. It has been fondly imagined that these gods and their respective worshippers would be quite irreconcilable, and undoubtedly the one has gained adherents by fulminations against the other: racialists against communists, and communists against racialists. One can still perceive jealousies between them, and some continuing differences, for example, about the correct manner of saluting one's fellow believers, about whether you style them "Proletariat" or "Volk," and about what saints are most potent, whether Marx and Lenin or Wagner and Nietzsche. Recent events have disclosed, nevertheless, that peculiarities of mythology are not necessarily divisive when it comes to arranging for a partition of foreign-mission fields. Perhaps, after all, these peculiarities are more fanciful than real. Perhaps, having performed the high service of enlisting the masses in the worship of totalitarian dictatorship, they may coalesce and syncretize into a neo-paganism analogous to that of primitive times.

Furthermore, totalitarian dictatorship has evolved a new pattern of methods and techniques. Behind a mask of plebiscites, popular elections, and occasional assemblings of a so-called parliament—which listens and applauds but doesn't really parley—the government actually functions through and with a single political party which comprises a minority, usually a small minority, of the nation, but which is more or less hand-picked, severely disciplined, and equipped with a monopoly of the means of influencing public opinion and enforcing the will of the dictator. The party permeates and ultimately dominates the army, the courts, the ubiquitous secret police, the schools and universities, the newspapers, radios, and cinemas, the telegraphs and telephones, the pulpits and rostrums, the youth organiza-

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tions, indeed all organizations, whether economic, social, or cultural. And a Russian Tsar, a Louis XIV or an Alexander the Great might well envy the speed and effectiveness with which dissenters are liquidated, doubters purged, and suspects gathered into concentration camps.

Still another novelty of totalitarianism is its exalting of might and force, not only as means to an end—there is precedent aplenty in Western history for that—but as an end in itself. In earlier and less totalitarian days, a despot who got rid of a foe or appropriated some neighbor's land went to considerable trouble, as a rule, to justify his action on conventional moral grounds. Now the totalitarian despot is hardly expected to offer any explanation at all, and when he does, it bears no trace of the Decalogue or the Sermon on the Mount. It suffices to echo the more up-to-date Nietzschean and pseudo-Darwinian principles that patience is a vice and that progress depends on a struggle for existence and *Lebensraum* for the fittest. Or it may suffice to recite the Marxian creed that proletarians have to fight for what they get and they are always right. The fact remains that brute force is boastfully invoked alike in the internal affairs and foreign policies of the totalitarian state. Force against Jews and Christians! Force against domestic critics! Force against Czechs and Albanians, Poles and Finns! The exalting of force and terrorism does not signify merely the immoral doctrine that the end justifies the means. It signifies an utter denial of any moral law superior to the might of dictators.

In sum, the dictatorial totalitarianism of today is a reaction —nay more, a revolt—against the whole historic civilization of the West. It is a revolt against the moderation and proportion of classical Greece, against the order and legality of ancient Rome, against the righteousness and justice of the Jewish prophets, against the charity and mercy and peace of Christ, against the whole vast cultural heritage of the Christian Church in middle ages and modern times, against the enlightenment, the reason, and the humanitarianism of the eighteenth century, against the liberal democracy of the nineteenth. It repudiates all these major constituents of our historic civilization and wars to the death on any group that retains affectionate memory of them. In Russia Christians and in Germany Jews are first

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gotten rid of. Presently it will be the turn of Christians in Germany and Jews in Russia, for if you are to erase the most constant memory of the Western mind you have to destroy Judaeo-Christianity both in its roots and in its flowers. Meanwhile the attack is pressed on other fronts—against champions of representative government and personal liberty, against counsellors of moderation, reason, or peace, against advocates of ordinary decency. For with Western civilization in any of its moral or cultural features, the proclaimed objectives of a Stalin or a Hitler are in flat contradiction. Stalin would build on its ruins an utterly new civilization, godless, materialistic, communistic. Hitler would resuscitate from under the ruins that tribal civilization of virility and valor which is imputed to pre-Christian aboriginal Teutons. Backward to primitive barbarism or onward to conscienceless utopia, that seems to be the choice of goals of the great contemporary revolt.

In the present crisis one may easily be tempted to pessimism. The factors which now make for totalitarianism, for its embodiment in dictatorship, and for its warfare against historic civilization seem so obvious and so overwhelming that the whole resulting process assumes in one's mind the nature of a cosmic drama—remorseless and inevitable. Yet in my philosophy at any rate, there is nothing absolutely inevitable. And in conclusion I would suggest two further antidotes for undue pessimism. First is the reflection that totalitarian dictatorship is a novelty of the last two decades only, a mere moment in the twenty-five centuries of Western civilization, and what has long endured is likely to outlast any untested novelty. Second is the recognition of the resourcefulness as well as of the inertia of the strange creature we call man. His inertia and submission have repeatedly brought him some sort of dictatorship and slavery. But his resourcefulness and rebelliousness have as often put him in the way of liberty, equality, fraternity. So the tide of human affairs ebbs and flows, for man belongs no less with the angels than with the beasts.

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